

DREAMING AGES HISTORY · BEDTIME COMPANION

Pilgrims on the Camino

A late-spring night at the hospital under the pass, around 1190

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A BEDTIME COMPANION

A hospital on the Spanish slope under the Pass of Cize, in the mountains at the edge of Spain. Santa María de Roncesvalles, one late-spring night around 1190, the old pilgrims' guidebook, and the road still waiting for morning, with a short list of places to read further, for the evenings when you would like to wander a little further.

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A HOSPITAL UNDER THE PASS

Roncesvalles and the road west

Let's begin at the hospital under the pass, on the Spanish slope of the mountain.



The hospital at Roncesvalles, Triacastela at the foot of the Galician mountain, and Santiago de Compostela, plotted at their real locations on a modern base map (Natural Earth). The pass of Ibañeta sits just above the hospital and is shown on the closer map. The roads and shorelines shown here are modern. The long road west is remembered in the episode, not walked tonight.

AT A GLANCE

- Late spring around 1190, at Santa María de Roncesvalles
- A house where pilgrims were received on the road to Compostela
- The summit above is called Charlemagne's Cross
- Tonight we stay inside, from dusk until the grey of morning

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Places you'll visit in the episode

A short, slow tour of the real places behind the story.

Santa María de Roncesvalles · The hospital on the Spanish slope under the pass of Ibañeta, a house where pilgrims were received on the road to Compostela. The night of the story stays inside this house.

The pass of Ibañeta · The mountain pass above the hospital, on the Spanish side of the crossing. The Xacopedia notes that the Codex Calixtinus speaks of a cross of Charlemagne raised at Ibañeta, a cross that has never been located.

The Pass of Cize, and Charlemagne's Cross · The old pilgrims' guidebook names the summit of the Pass of Cize as Charlemagne's Cross. Pilgrims plant their own crosses there so that a thousand crosses may be found, the first station of prayer on the road.

The road to Compostela · Santiago de Compostela, the shrine of St James at the western end of the road. The episode remembers that road from inside the hospital, and does not walk it tonight.

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Places you'll visit in the episode

The foot of the Galician mountain · The guidebook says that at the foot of the Galician mountain, pilgrims take a stone and carry it onward to make lime for the apostle's church. The Guide names that place as Triacastela, and the lime-works as Castañeda.

Lavacolla · Near the end of the road, two miles before the city, French pilgrims wash the dirt from their bodies in the river Lavacolla, out of respect for the apostle.

The apostle's church · The old guidebook speaks of the light of lamps and candles in the apostle's church, of window light coming through glass, and of five windows throwing a strong light on the apostle's altar.

The scrip, the staff, and the shell · A blessing spoken in the house calls the scrip the habit of the journey and the staff support for the road, so as to reach the feet of St James and return with joy. A scallop shell in the scrip is already the sign pilgrims used on the road to Compostela.

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ONE LATE-SPRING NIGHT

Through the hospital, around 1190

Here is the night in the hospital, from the door to first grey light.

THE NIGHT AT A GLANCE

Dusk	The Guide	The shell	Dawn
The hospital door	Charlemagne's Cross	Sign of the road	Grey on the threshold

The walk follows one late-spring night around the year 1190, inside the hospital under the pass. The house, the road and the old pilgrims' guidebook are historical. The people we follow tonight are imagined.

Around 1190

Late spring, in the mountains at the edge of Spain. A night at Santa María de Roncesvalles is a narrative frame in a year when the house already received pilgrims on the road to Compostela, not a dated event.

The guidebook already in use

The Codex Calixtinus, the old pilgrims' guidebook, lists the towns and stages from the Pass of Cize onward, so that pilgrims setting out can work out the expenses of the journey.

Charlemagne's Cross

At the summit of the Pass of Cize, pilgrims plant their own crosses, the first station of prayer on the road.

A blessing at the door

The scrip is the habit of the journey, and the staff is support for the road, so as to reach the feet of St James and return with joy.

ONE LATE-SPRING NIGHT

From the welcome to morning

The blessing, the river near the city, and the lights of the apostle's church.



A right to a welcome

Pilgrims of St James, poor or rich, have a right to hospitality and a respectful welcome. Whoever receives the pilgrim receives not only St James but the Lord.

Stones for lime

At the foot of the Galician mountain, pilgrims take a stone and carry it onward to make lime for the apostle's church.

The river Lavacolla

Two miles before Compostela, French pilgrims wash in the river, out of respect for the apostle.

ONE LATE-SPRING NIGHT

From the welcome to morning

The scallop shell

A scallop shell is already the sign pilgrims used on the road to Compostela.

Lamps, glass and five windows

The guidebook remembers the light of lamps and candles in the apostle's church, window light through glass, and five windows throwing a strong light on the apostle's altar.

Until the grey of morning

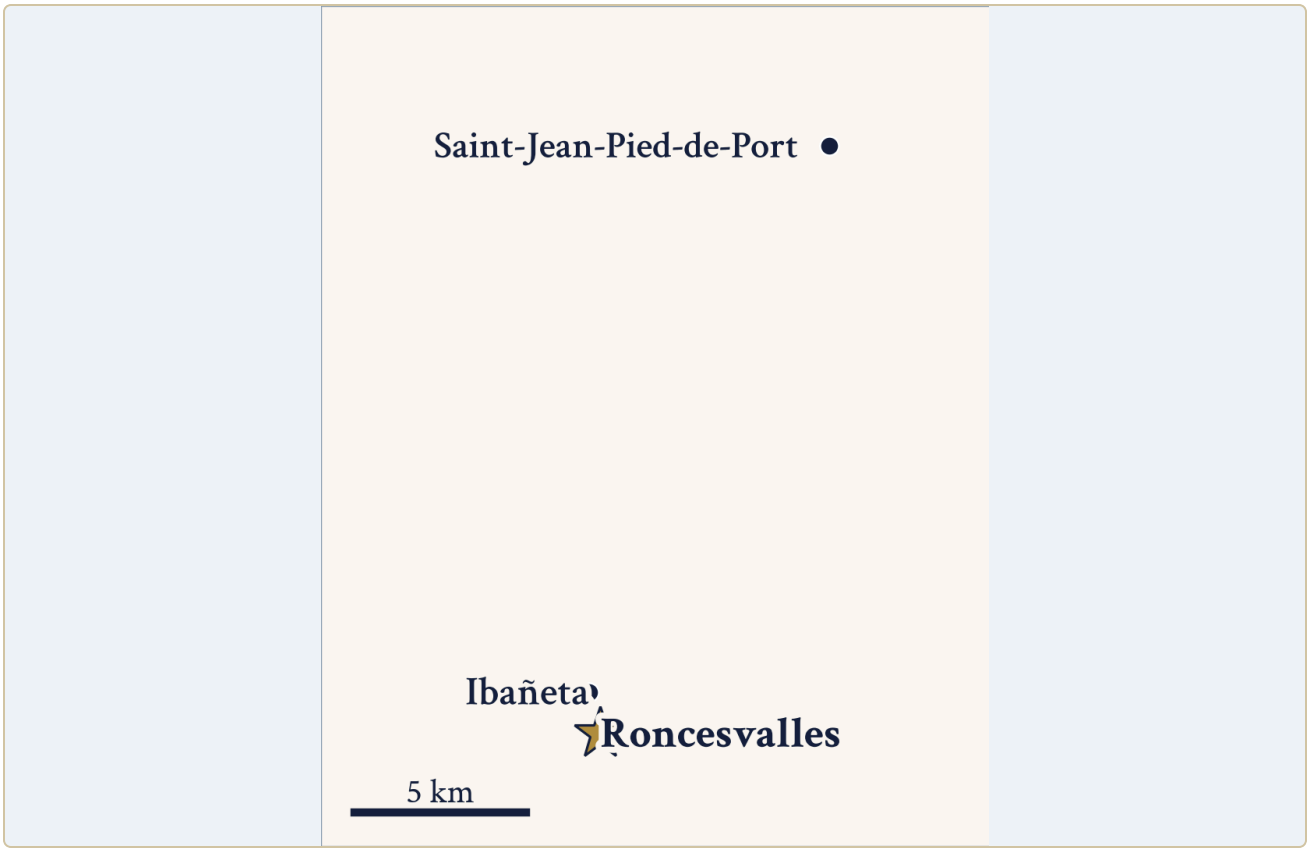
The story stays inside the hospital from the first dusk at the door until grey light stands in the gap.

A specific night around 1190 is a frame, not a recorded date. The first recorded royal protection of Roncesvalles belongs to Sancho VI the Wise, in October 1176, which is earlier than this evening and is not spoken in the episode. Later priors and papal bulls (from 1199 and 1203) fall after this night and are not used as if they had already happened.

A CLOSER MAP

The hospital and the pass

Now let's step closer, to the hospital and the pass above it.



The hospital at Roncesvalles and the pass of Ibañeta, with Saint-Jean-Pied-de-Port on the far side of the crossing.

FROM THE RECORD

- The guidebook lists the stages from the Pass of Cize
- At Triacastela, pilgrims take a stone for lime
- French pilgrims wash at Lavacolla, two miles before the city

People you'll meet

The real names, and a few imagined ones, that you'll hear along the way.

The imagined household · Alain, a pilgrim bound for Compostela, and Tomás, Elena and Isabel of the hospital, are imagined. People very like them kept this house and walked this road, but these four are not historical individuals.

St James · The apostle of the shrine at Compostela. The blessing, the right of hospitality, and the lights of the church are all spoken with his name. He has no speaking part in the episode.

The old pilgrims' guidebook · The Codex Calixtinus, already in use on this road, names the summit as Charlemagne's Cross, lists the stages from the Pass of Cize, and describes Lavacolla and the lights of the apostle's church. A prologue later attributed the collection to Pope Callixtus II, who died in 1124, in order to give the book an air of authenticity; that attribution is not settled, and is not spoken as a lesson in the episode.

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WHILE YOU LISTEN

Things to spot, and what is real

A few small things to listen for, and a note on what is found and what is imagined.

THINGS TO SPOT IN THE EPISODE

- The summit called Charlemagne's Cross, and a thousand pilgrim crosses
- The scrip as the habit of the journey, and the staff as support for the road
- A scallop shell already used as the sign of the road to Compostela
- The river Lavacolla, two miles before the city
- Five windows throwing a strong light on the apostle's altar

WHAT WE KNOW, AND WHAT WE IMAGINE

The hospital under the pass, the road to Compostela, the summit called Charlemagne's Cross, the lime stones, Lavacolla, the scallop shell, and the lights of the apostle's church are historical, and come from the old guidebook or from the house itself. A night around 1190 is a story frame. The named ordinary people of this particular evening are imagined.

Museums and places

Museums & places

Codex Calixtinus, English version of Book V: the pilgrims' guide that names Charlemagne's Cross, the stages from the Pass of Cize, Lavacolla, and the lights of the apostle's church.

Catedral de Santiago, Historia: the cathedral's own account of the shrine and the church at Compostela.

Eloísa Ramírez Vaquero, La comunidad regular de Santa María de Roncesvalles (siglos XII-XIX): a sourced history of the hospital under the pass, including the 1176 protection of Sancho VI.

José Manuel Rodríguez Montañés, Bendición del peregrino y sus atributos simbólicos: the blessing of the pilgrim, and the scrip, staff and shell as signs of the road (Acción Cultural Española / Xacobeo).





Artistic impressions made for the episode. They are not historical records.

FOR ANOTHER QUIET EVENING

One last thought

A BEDTIME QUESTION

If you sat out this night in the hospital under the pass, what would you hold in mind longest: the crosses at the summit, the lime stones of the Galician mountain, or the five windows over the apostle's altar?

"The summit of the Pass of Cize is called Charlemagne's Cross, and pilgrims plant their own crosses there so that a thousand crosses may be found, the first station of prayer on the road."

LISTEN TO THE FULL EPISODE ON YOUTUBE OR YOUTUBE MUSIC

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